

LEARNING JAPANESE MARKETING STYLE IS KEY TO SUCCESS

By Ruth Shiraishi

About three weeks ago, I had the honour of attending an IT Club meeting at the Indian Embassy in Tokyo. Mr. Som Mittal, Chairman of Nasscom, was addressing some 80 business leaders. Although, Mr. Mittal's speech outlining efforts to increase business activity between India and Japan was informative, an important statement of the evening came from India IT Club Director Mr. Harsh Obrai, himself a veteran Tokyo businessman.

"No longer", stated Mr. Obrai, "Can we blame cultural and language issues as barriers to our success in Japan. Many of us have Japanese staff, speak Japanese and have lived here some 20 years. We also witness specific examples of great success in several Indian firms here". This was the type of breakthrough comment that negates status quo and pushes people to the next level.

I am sure all participants were inspired by his words and will be seeking that secret formula a few have found for success in Japan. Since arriving from the US, I have worked solely in Japanese firms for some twenty years and my third-person point of view (American female working with Indian companies from within a Japanese firm) allows a bird's eye view of how Japanese companies deal and how foreign firms could further benefit from the myriad opportunities here. Indian companies I've encountered approach business in a straightforward, rational, organized and definitive way. On the other hand, Japanese firms are utterly unique with an approach that is fuzzy and fluid but at the same time, careful and conservative.

Business associates in Japan are treated exactly like immediate family members. A large part of business includes "caring" for the prospective or current customer. The proper way to greet a business associate in Japan is to say "Thank you for taking care of me". For the Japanese customer you are always

available and always there to meet any demand with a positive, patient attitude. Your Japanese counterpart will take for granted that you are available 24/7 to respond to issues as they arise. There is an entire world of inner-company workings for your Japanese counterpart that you will never see and can only support with lightning response to any request. This will create a deep and lasting trust and once you have that, your relationship is pretty much set in stone.

When you receive the all-important introduction to a new company from a contact in Japan, set up a "greeting" appointment. Begin with a brief explanation of your business but spend most of the time asking questions about your counterpart. What are their goals and dreams, who are their valued customers? Give freely of your knowledge and show that your focus is on THEIR success. If asked how you can help, demure by saying you are not sure, will think about it and contact them later. A pat "We can do it" answer in Japan is generally not trusted. You will then need to do follow-up visits, provide information, give your ideas and "be there". Then, one unbelievable day, you will receive a call from your counterpart about an issue on which he or she would like your advice. Give 100% to help resolve the issue even if there is no monetary return.

Following this, there will be some relatively small order that comes your way. It may seem insignificant, but for the Japanese side sending you business for the first time, it is a major step of faith. From there on, it is your dedication and careful attention to detail that will ultimately lead you to a truly successful and long term business relationship. In the new economy Japan's leadership is a given. Learning the business style of this new leader is an investment of time and energy that could reap great reward.

(As told to Veeshal Bakshi)



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